

Corner kicks

Corners are one of football's most important attacking restarts. The rule itself is simple, but attacking and defending corners are among the most rehearsed parts of the modern game.

Restarts and set pieces [Read the rules guide](#)

When a corner is awarded

A corner is awarded to the attacking team in a few specific situations. The usual one is when the defending team are the last to touch the ball before it crosses their own goal line, without a goal being scored.

The whole of the ball must cross the goal line, on the ground or in the air, without a goal being scored. If the defending team were the last to touch it, the corner kick is taken from the corner area nearest to where the ball went out.

A corner is also awarded if a goalkeeper controls the ball with their hand or arm inside their own penalty area for more than eight seconds. In that case, the corner is taken from the corner area nearest to where the goalkeeper was penalised.

A corner is also awarded if the team taking a goal kick unfairly delay the restart and the ball is not in play by the end of the referee's five-second countdown.

In rarer cases, a corner can also follow if a team puts the ball directly into its own goal from a restart from which an own goal cannot be scored, such as a kick-off, throw-in, free kick, goal kick or corner kick. A dropped ball that enters a team's own goal before it has touched at least two players is also restarted with a corner.

If an attacking player last touched the ball before it crossed the defending team's goal line, and none of those special cases applies, the restart is a goal kick instead.

How a corner is taken

The corner-kick technique is straightforward, but the rules around the corner area are precise.

The ball must be stationary and placed in the correct corner area — usually the quarter-circle nearest to where the ball went out, or nearest to the goalkeeper's position for the eight-second offence. The corner flag must not be moved. The kicker can be any player from the attacking team and the ball is in play as soon as it is clearly kicked and moves.

All opposing players must be at least 9.15 metres (10 yards) from the corner area until the ball is in play. After the kick, the kicker cannot touch the ball again until another player has touched it.

Goals from corners

A goal can be scored directly from a corner.

If the ball goes straight into the opponents' goal from a corner, without anyone else touching it, the goal is awarded. This is sometimes called an Olympic goal — they are rare, but they happen.

Most corners are not aimed at goal directly. They are crossed into the penalty area for an attacking player to head or shoot, or played short to a teammate who can then deliver a more controlled cross.

Attacking a corner

Corners are one of the most rehearsed parts of the modern game.

Inswinging cross

The ball curves towards the goal as it crosses the area, usually delivered by a right-footed player from the left side or a left-footed player from the right side.

Outswinging cross

The ball curves away from the goal as it crosses the area, dropping for attackers running onto it.

Short corner

A short pass to a teammate near the corner. The ball is then crossed or worked into a different angle of attack.

Near-post and far-post runs

Attackers make rehearsed runs to specific areas to meet the cross, often using blocks or screens to free a teammate.

[Read about corner routines](#)

Defending a corner

Defending corners is just as practised as attacking them.

Man-marking

Each defender is responsible for a specific attacker, following them around the box and trying to win headers and clearances.

Zonal marking

Defenders cover specific areas of the penalty area rather than individual attackers, attacking the ball as it comes through their zone.

Mixed marking

A combination of the two, with key defenders zonal at the front of the box and others picking up specific attackers.

Second-ball positions

Defenders and midfielders position themselves to win loose balls if the first clearance only reaches the edge of the penalty area.